

The price of the beautiful game

In 2026, FIFA's World Cup ticket prices leave many fans struggling to participate in the **beloved event** they cherish.

Ayon Sengupta
sportstar@thehindu.co.in

The World Cup has always belonged to its fans. Yet in North America, where FIFA's showpiece has arrived amid record revenues and unprecedented commercial interest, many supporters are discovering that being part of the spectacle comes at a price that is becoming increasingly difficult to justify.

Karan, originally from northern India, has been a regular at MetLife Stadium for years, watching the New York Giants and Jets in the NFL. But attending the World Cup has proved beyond his reach.

"My wife and I have been constantly scanning the internet for the last three months," he says. "But no luck so far. Most matches in New York are priced at over USD 1,200."

Instead, he is considering travelling to Philadelphia, where tickets for some matches remain relatively more affordable.

For Francisco, a Brazilian from Bahia who has lived in New Jersey for three decades, the frustration is similar. While he is delighted by the New York Knicks' long-awaited NBA title, he could not bring himself to spend what it would take to watch Brazil's opening game against Morocco.

"We can't afford the tickets," he says. "And getting there is even more expensive because ride-sharing services aren't allowed close to the stadium."

The closest he came to World Cup action was paying USD 70 to attend Morocco's final pre-World Cup friendly against Norway at the Sports Illustrated Stadium in Harrison, New Jersey.

"I love soccer and follow our players wherever they play. Carlo Ancelotti hasn't had enough time with the



team yet, but this squad has potential. Brazil will get through this group," Francisco says optimistically.

Their stories have become increasingly common during the opening days of the tournament. Concerns over ticket prices have been amplified by reports of empty seats at some matches and criticism from politicians and supporters alike.

Among the most vocal critics has been New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani, who argues that sport should not become "a luxury commodity". His administration pushed FIFA to allocate a limited number of discounted tickets for locals. "A World Cup is coming to our backyard, and we want to ensure working-class New Yorkers have the